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Doctrinal Basis of the British Reformed Fellowship

“The basis of the BRF shall be the inspired, infallible, inerrant Scriptures of the Old and New Testaments as summarized and systematized in the Reformed confessions, specifically the *Three Forms of Unity* and the *Westminster Standards*.”

British Reformed Fellowship

Founded in 1990 by a group of Reformed Christians concerned for the defence of the Historic Reformed Faith in the British Isles.

Aims and Objectives

1. To promote knowledge of the Reformed Faith as is defined in the Doctrinal Basis through the publication of a quarterly journal (*British Reformed Journal*) and by organizing a biennial national family conference and other conferences and lectures as opportunities arise, through media, internet and any lawful means.
2. To facilitate the networking of Reformed Christians scattered throughout the British Isles, and to enable opportunities for supporting and communicating with one another.
3. To promote Reformed causes such as Christian education, Christian benevolence, biblical ecumenism and fellowship throughout the British Isles.
4. To provide a source of advice, information and support to Reformed Christians who are living and working in isolation. To provide practical answers to difficult questions arising among Reformed Christians isolated from fellowship.

Editorial: More Loving Than God? (3)

Samuel Watterson

How to Measure God's Love

In this series of editorials, we have been analysing an argument against God's sovereignty in salvation made by Open Theist Jesse Morell who claimed, "I'm more loving than your God! I want all these people to be saved!" We have seen how modern proponents of the "well-meant offer" on occasion have made essentially the same blasphemous and hypocritical argument, and how the Scriptures specifically refute the self-contradictory teaching of hypo-Calvinism (Rom. 9:18). We underscored the fundamental flaw in the argument, its error of measuring love by the scope of its objects, and turned the argument on its head by demonstrating that God does not demand a universal unlimited love of us for every creature. Rather, against God's enemies, there is a proper place for a holy hatred (Ps. 139:21-22) and even cursing (I Cor. 16:22), including a longing for their eventual destruction (Rev. 6:10), and even a rejoicing in the execution of God's justice and vengeance against them (Rev. 18:20).

Having also explained some of the evil theological and practical consequences of this false doctrine of an unlimited universal love (either in God or required of us), we should now examine more positively how Scripture itself measures God's love. Finally, we will consider how this relates to our calling to love.

Before we continue, we should ask whether this is an appropriate inquiry or unwarranted curiosity. If the measure of God's love extends beyond the limits of our comprehension, is it idle speculation to consider the subject? Such arguments are sometimes made in churches where it is preferred that the "laity" are kept at a certain level of ignorance, so that there are fewer opinions upon which disagreements may occur or, worse, so that the people are easier to direct and even to control. The Scriptures, however, encourage us always to learn and to know our God more deeply according to what He has revealed (Prov. 2:1-9; Rom. 15:4; I Cor. 10:11; II Tim. 3:16-17). Paul prayed concerning this subject specifically for the Ephesian saints:

For this cause I bow my knees unto the Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, Of whom the whole family in heaven and earth is named, That he would grant you, according to the riches of his glory, to be strengthened with might by his Spirit in the inner man; That Christ may dwell in your hearts by faith; that ye, being rooted and grounded in love, May be able to comprehend with all saints what is the breadth, and length, and depth, and height; And to know the love of Christ, which passeth knowledge, that ye might be filled with all the fulness of God (Eph. 3:14-19).

He finished his prayer by assuring us that God is “able to do exceeding abundantly above all that we ask or think, according to the power that worketh in us” (Eph. 3:20). With this confidence and boldness of faith in Christ, along with reverence, we ought to seek to grow in this spiritual comprehension (I Cor. 2:7-16). Christ has taught us that to know our God is eternal life and we cannot know God without knowing His love (John 17:3; I John 4:8). This pursuit is, therefore, essential to the Christian life.

We will first consider the ideas in Scripture which relate to a definition of God’s love generally. Then we will conform and refine these concepts according to God’s Being and attributes. Following this, we will see how this love of God is revealed in His names and actually demonstrated in His works, both in Himself and with reference to the creation. Finally, we will relate the measure of God’s love in Himself to how the manifestation of His love in us must be perfected (I John 4:7-12).

A Biblical Definition of Love

The words translated “love” in Scripture have a very broad usage. With God as the subject of the verb, in the Old Testament, the Hebrew word *ahab* is used and sometimes *chashaq* or *racham*, whereas in the New Testament the Greek word *agape* or occasionally *phileo* is used. Probably the most obvious and fundamental idea concerning love, consistently throughout Scripture, is that love has a subject and an object. In the activity of love, there is necessarily a desire or will from the subject which is directed towards the object. This de-

sire or will from the subject is derived from a favourable affection, disposition and/or determination of the heart or mind of the subject towards the object. Therefore, the subject is always personal (e.g., God or man) whereas the object can be a thing, whether physical (e.g., places, food or sleep) or abstract (e.g., wisdom, righteousness or evil). This fundamental affection or disposition is represented by the word *ahab* or *phileo*.

Depending on the nature of the subject and the object, this affection is expressed (or manifested) by different means and with different goals. The love required of us for God is explained as requiring our whole being so that we are actively and wholly devoted to God in all that we do with all the might of our body and soul (Deut. 6:5; cf. Luke 10:27). We do not expect all the usages of the term “love” to imply such devotion. A man who “loves” pizza, for example, may go out of his way a little to find it or pay a little extra for it, or he may ignore his affection for pizza on occasion for the sake of some higher goal. A man “loves” pizza with the aim to eat it, whereas a man “loves” a work of art with the goal to look at it. Similarly, with respect to love for people, there may be different measures or kinds of affection with different goals. The affection Abraham had for his son Isaac was very different to the affection Isaac had for venison (Gen. 22:2; 27:4).

The word *chashaq* expresses that the subject delights in the object of his love with the desire or goal of clinging to or joining with the object. It is used to describe the connecting of pillars around the court of the tabernacle with silver rods (Ex. 27:10, 17; 38:17, 28). It is used synonymously with *ahab* in reference to God setting His love upon Israel and delighting in their fathers (Deut. 7:7-8; 10:15). It is also used to refer to the love a man has for a woman by which he desires to have her as his wife, that is, to cleave to her in the bond of marriage (Deut. 21:11; cf. Gen. 2:24).

Chashaq expresses a delight in another which involves the desire to establish a relational bond or union (or covenant; Mal. 2:14). Such a harmonious and loving bond or union (as in marriage) implies mutual love from the subject to the object and from the object to the subject, in a perfect and virtuous cycle (Col. 3:14).

Another word, *racham* describes the activity or life that is desired within

such a bond or union. This word is used in the sense of having compassion, pity or mercy upon another. Significantly, this is the word used to describe the mercy or compassion of God upon some and not others, as quoted by Paul in his rebuke against those who object to God's sovereignty in salvation (Ex. 33:19; Rom. 9:15). The word carries the idea of caressing or fondling another in loving compassion. In this way, it is often translated pity or mercy with respect to those who are in a miserable condition in great need of such compassion to relieve their misery.

The Psalmist speaks of his love for God using *racham*, which is translated "love" in all the English translations I could find (Ps. 18:1). In that David has this love for God and God neither has misery nor is in need of mercy or pity, the term can be used more generally to describe the loving compassion which one has for another, such that the subject shows his or her love by doing good with respect to the object. This is the word which perhaps most closely relates to the explanation of *agape* love in the New Testament, though *agape* underscores the willingness to sacrifice and suffer loss for the sake of the good of others, that is, considering the good of the other above one's own (I Cor. 13:1-7).

At this point, we already have a pretty well-rounded concept of personal love in its highest sense, a favourable affection or disposition of the subject which desires and delights in the object with the will or determination to cling to or join with the object and have compassion upon the object by doing the object good. There are some elements we could add. With reference to lovers (typically in a negative context), Scripture uses the word *agab* which means "to breathe after," expressing a very strong desire (Eze. 23:9).

Finally, the noun *dod* can be used to refer to a sensual or erotic love or simply one who is beloved (Prov. 7:18). However, since the word is used predominantly throughout Song of Solomon (almost two thirds of the occurrences), it is a significant word to be understood with reference to the love between God and His people (Eph. 5:32; Rev. 19:7-9). It has a root meaning "to boil" and is related to another word which often implies intimacy, the verb translated "to know" (e.g., Gen. 4:1). In this kind of love, there is an intimate companionship and knowledge which overflows in joy and pleasure which is "better than wine" (Song 1:2). The delightful one called "beloved" is also called "friend" (Song 5:16).

According to His Being

We can apply this understanding of the range of usage of the words rendered “love” in Scripture (and its closely related concepts) to what we know about God’s Being to understand in what sense love is an attribute of God. In taking this approach, we are following a systematic-theological method. For the sake of time and space, and to concentrate on our subject, I will not attempt to prove at this time all the theological points I intend to raise. To most of our readers, these will already be established uncontroversial points upon we can build (cf. Heb. 6:1-3). To the rest, for further explanation and proofs, I advise consulting commentaries on the related Scriptures that I cite, commentaries on the Reformed and ecumenical confessions, as well as works of biblically-based systematic theology of which there are many available.

Appropriately, the first point we should make concerning any attribute of God is in relation to His unity, as this simple point is the preface to the first and greatest commandment (Deut. 6:4; Mark 12:29). That Jehovah our God is one Jehovah means that His love in Himself is one love. There cannot therefore be two or more loves in God. Closely related to God’s unity is His divine simplicity because He is spirit (John 4:24). That God is “one only simple ... Being” means also that He is “without ... parts” (*Belgic Confession* 1; *Westminster Confession* 2:1).

This necessarily means that God’s attributes are all simply different ways to describe the one ultimate perfection of His Being, so that God’s attributes are not only in perfect harmony, but cannot be divided from each other and cannot be considered to have different degrees. There cannot, therefore, be different degrees or kinds of love in God when we consider love as an attribute of God. God’s simplicity and unity mean also that He is His attributes, that is, His attributes are essential to His very Being, not as component parts but to be identified directly as His Being. So the Scriptures tell us: “God is love” (I John 4:8).

Considering that God is perfect (which is another way to describe His simplicity), His attributes are necessarily perfect so that we may also consider love as an attribute of God in the very highest sense of what love means in its perfection (Matt. 5:48). We must, therefore, put far from us all the lesser

ideas about love, such as the “love” for mere physical objects such as food or even weaker kinds of love for people, such as one might have for a stranger compared to a dear friend or relative. Whatever God’s love is in Himself, it cannot be less than perfect.

Because God is perfect, He is also necessarily unchangeable, for, if He could change, this would be a change to something less than perfect and being able to become less than perfect would, therefore, be an imperfection in itself (Ps. 102:27; Mal. 3:6; James 1:17). The name Jehovah, by which God is particularly known by His saved people, means “I AM,” by which we understand that God (and, therefore, God’s love) remains always the same (Ex. 3:14). Since God cannot change, He is also “without ... passions” (*Westminster Confession* 2:1).

God’s impassibility does not mean that He has no zealous disposition of the heart (also since love in its most basic sense implies such a disposition), but rather that He is not subject to any kind of external stimulus or condition by which any kind of change might be induced upon Him, such as hunger, weariness, affliction or any other kind of mutable or transitory excitement of feeling or emotion (Num. 23:19; Isa. 40:28; Acts 14:15). Hence the English Standard Version (ESV) typically translates God’s lovingkindness or mercy (*chesed*) as “steadfast love” (e.g., Hos. 2:19). As a favourable disposition or affection (if we may use the term), God’s merciful love is as unchanging and immutable as His mercy (Ps. 89:28).

When Scripture presents us with God’s immutability, it is usually illustrated in terms of His eternity since, as creatures, we see that everything changes with respect to time. It is not so with the everlasting God because He “inhabiteth eternity” (Isa. 57:15). He both fills all of time and is also not subject to it or anything within it. Jehovah transcends time, having always been even before the beginning (Ps. 90:2). Therefore, God’s love also is from everlasting (Jer. 31:3; Eph. 1:4-5). In connection with God’s eternity, His infinity means that His love is not only eternal but infinite.

In the introduction, I indicated that, because of God’s infinity, His love cannot be limited and cannot be completely measured (except by Himself). Because God is by nature incomprehensible to limited finite creatures, His love cannot be fully comprehended by us (Rom. 11:33; I Cor. 2:10; Eph. 3:19).

God's love, as a divine perfection, cannot be measured and, therefore, we cannot speak about any greater or lesser love in God when speaking of what His love is in Himself (Job 11:7).

With respect to God's transcendence (which we must address when considering His perfection and His infinity and eternity), although we have sought for a basic definition of love among creatures, we must understand that God's love is as far above and beyond and superior to all love that belongs to creatures as He is transcendent above creation (Ps. 8:1; 113:4-6; Isa. 40:15-25; 55:9). The Psalmist tells us "as the heaven is high above the earth, so great is his mercy [*chesed*] toward them that fear him" (Ps. 103:11). The point is that heaven is the highest that we can imagine, and so high that it is beyond the possibility of reaching, so that the greatness of God's lovingkindness transcends any measure we can envisage.

Related to God's transcendence is His aseity, which is also expressed in the divine name, Jehovah. It is also necessary from a consideration of God's eternity alone (Ps. 90:2; Isa. 45:18). God's aseity means that He depends upon nothing outside Himself, having His own existence in and of Himself without respect to anything else, whereas everything in creation stands only by His word of power to uphold it (Acts 17:24-25; Rom. 11:36; Col. 1:16-17). God's aseity means that His love does not depend upon the creature for its existence, measure or perfection in any sense. Therefore, we cannot say that God's love improved, increased or was made in any way more perfect by creation or redemption (Job 35:7; 41:11; Ps. 16:2; Rom. 11:35).

Such is the blind folly of those who dream of measuring the beauty and perfection of God's love by the number of its creaturely objects. The universalists imagine that we do injustice to the love of God by denying that His love is for every single person who ever lived but, by measuring God's love by a finite number of objects, they are actually limiting the infinite love of God. God's love is full and complete and perfect in Himself without respect to any creature, so that His love is as independent, immovable and unshakeable as a solid rock (Deut. 32:4; Ps. 18:30-31).

God's aseity implies His sovereignty. If God is wholly independent and transcendent, then He also has absolute authority and freedom to do whatever He

wills (Dan. 4:35). Such complete sovereignty includes God's ability or power to do whatever He desires, that is, His omnipotence, so that He therefore actually does whatever He wants (Ps. 115:3; Isa. 46:9-10). With respect to God, everything in creation is like a lump of clay in the hands of a potter who uses the clay for whatever purpose suits him with no input or influence whatsoever from the clay itself (Prov. 16:4; Jer. 18:4-6; Rom. 9:21). God's love is, therefore, also completely and utterly free (Ps. 51:12; II Cor. 3:17). Only God Himself, and nothing or no-one else, determines the love of God (Deut. 7:7-8).

God, therefore, loves whom He wills just as He has loving compassion on whom He wills (Ex. 33:19; Rom. 9:15). Because God is omnipotent, His love is also omnipotent, that is, the love of God accomplishes without fail all that His love wills to accomplish. In this way, the loving desire of God for the object of His love is necessarily fulfilled. There is no possibility of an unrequited love when we speak of the love of God, and here again the universalists blunder as they would have us believe that most of the objects of His love do not and will not love God for eternity. In contrast, Scripture teaches that God's love has definite and certain effects according to His omnipotence (John 3:16; Eph. 1:4, 19; 2:4-5; Titus 3:3-5; I John 4:19).

All of the above assumes that God's love is a personal, willing, thoughtful, knowing and desiring love. This is because God is spirit (John 4:24). God's spirituality means that His love is necessarily a rational and moral love, not like the kind of "love" a dog has for his master, a "love" which is neither properly rational nor moral.

As we have seen, love is often presented in terms of knowing (Amos 3:2). With respect to God's knowledge, we must understand His omniscience. God knows Himself fully and completely, including all His eternal plans and purposes for creation and everything in creation through all of history (Isa. 46:10-11; Acts 15:18). God's love, therefore, thinks upon and knows its object intimately and fully with a personal desire and with delight, actively and powerfully willing to do all that such love wills to do, that is, to establish and maintain and live in an indissoluble relational bond or union (i.e., covenant) of loving perfection in harmonious mutual comfort and joy (Gen. 9:9-17; 17:7; Ps. 89:28-37; Jer. 31:33-34; Mal. 2:4-7; Matt. 26:28; Gal. 3:15-17; Heb. 9:15).

Finally, God's immanence means that His love is also near to the creation and must necessarily involve the creation in some way such that God's love is manifest in it (John 3:16; Acts 17:27-28; Rom. 5:8; I John 4:9). God's immanence and infinity also implies His omnipresence, so that the object of His love cannot go anywhere to escape or be separated from the all-knowing, all-present and all-powerful love of God (Ps. 139:7-18; Rom. 8:38-39).

According to His Attributes

So far we have mainly constrained ourselves to a consideration of the implications for God's love regarding what theologians typically categorize as His incommunicable attributes. God's love properly belongs to His communicable attributes as we have seen from our consideration of love among creatures. Again, because of God's simplicity and unity, all His communicable attributes must be harmonized so that, for example, God's goodness means that His love is good (Ex. 33:19; 34:6; Ps. 100:5). That God is good means that, because of His moral excellence, He is full of infinite riches of pleasantness in which delight and pleasure is taken (Ps. 65:4; 107:9; Jer. 31:14). God's love, therefore, satisfies its object with goodness, even the goodness of God Himself communicated and bestowed upon the object (Ps. 16:11; 36:7-8). God's love in Himself must then also have a good object, so that God delights and takes pleasure in the goodness of the object of His love (Matt. 19:17).

God is also holy which means that He is zealously devoted to His own glorious perfection in absolute purity and He is utterly separated from anything which is not consecrated to Himself (Isa. 6:3). This necessarily implies an antithetical, committed and jealous love for a certain object, and not for another. We often think of holiness in terms of moral purity but God's holiness is much more than this. With respect to God's love, His holiness means that God ardently and unwaveringly loves with His whole infinite Being, and that the object of His love must also necessarily be wholly dedicated to God in holiness and love (Prov. 8:17; John 16:27; Eph. 1:4). His holiness also means that the object of God's love is necessarily Himself, which ought to have been apparent already from a consideration of God's eternity and aseity. This is also indicated in Scripture in various ways (Prov. 8:22-30; Luke 3:22; John 1:18; Eph. 1:6; Heb. 1:5) but we will treat this subject more fully when considering the Holy Trinity and God's works with respect to Himself (*ad intra*).

Similarly, God's righteousness is His perfect and unchangeable adherence to His own moral standard, for He defines what is righteous by His own moral perfection. Because God loves righteousness, He loves justice and will judge according to His own righteousness (Ps. 11:7; 33:5; 37:28; 99:4; Isa. 61:8). The object of God's love must, therefore, be perfectly righteous (Ps. 45:7; 146:8; John 14:21-23).

The exercise of God's judgment is tied inseparably to His lovingkindness in Scripture (Jer. 9:24). Judgment for the righteous object of God's love is not negative, but involves a loving vindication, justification and assurance (Ps. 7:8; 26:1-8; 43:1; 91:14-16; Isa. 32:16-17; Luke 18:7; Rom. 8:1, 16). This communication of love in declaring the object to be righteous and beloved belongs to the activity of love in tender compassion towards its object. The object does not need to be miserable or in doubt for this activity to be welcome and necessary for God's love in its perfection (Mark 1:11).

Closely related to God's righteousness and justice is His faithfulness and truth, such that He always does what He purposes to do and it is impossible for God to lie (Deut. 7:9; Heb. 6:17-18; Rev. 19:11). God's love is, therefore, faithful so that, even when Israel is adulterous, God maintains His betrothal with her and thereby causes her to know Him in love (Hos. 2:14-20).

That God's love is true means that it is absolutely sincere. God's love cannot be a mere feeling or expression without real action and power (cf. I John 3:18). Sincere love involves deeds which effectively manifest that love, so that God's love is always bestowed upon His object with mighty actions accomplishing the goal of His love by His infinite power. Because God is also wise, His love is full of wisdom so that He perfectly uses His infinite knowledge in the best possible way to accomplish His loving deeds (Jude 24-25).

That God is gracious means that He is full of attractive and precious beauty and splendour in Himself, and that God has such a favourable disposition to His own perfect beauty and glory in His sight according to which He communicates and bestows beautiful favour upon the objects of His grace (Gen. 6:8; Ps. 45:2; 84:11; Prov. 22:1; Ecc. 3:11). In God's love, there is, therefore, a favourable disposition towards the object of His love (Ps. 118:6; Rom. 8:31-35). The activity of God's love is also necessarily a gracious activity in which

beautifying favour is bestowed upon the object of His love. The object of God's love must also be favourable and delightful in His sight, that is, full of beauty (Ps. 45:11; 90:17; 149:4; Song 1:15-16; 4:7, 10; Isa. 61:3; 62:4-5).

God's mercy in Himself appears hard to explain, because we normally consider mercy with respect to a miserable object and mercy as the lifting of that object out of misery (Ps. 40:1-3). Because God is full of mercy, there can be no misery in God (Rom. 9:5). God's mercy or compassion in Himself is the lovingkindness and tender care according to which He blesses Himself with goodness (cf. Ps. 67:1).

God's merciful love, therefore, encompasses and embraces its object with tenderness and care, so that the object of His love is blessed with goodness and comfort (which does not imply any lack of comfort in God but rather the opposite; Ps. 34:6-8; Isa. 51:3; II Cor. 1:3-4). This implies a constant loving nearness and presence, so that God dwells with and upholds the object of His love, as His beloved is hidden in refuge under the safe, secure and comfortable cover and shadow of His wings (Deut. 33:27; Ps. 91:1-2; 139:3-7; I John 4:16; Rev. 21:3). God's aseity means that He depends upon and upholds Himself, because He is full of loving mercy and comfort.

Scripture also speaks of God's longsuffering, forbearance, patience or slowness to anger (Ps. 86:15; Rom. 2:4). Properly speaking, God cannot suffer but, with respect to time, because He is eternal, He is willing and able to endure the offence against His majesty of the vessels appointed to wrath for the sake of His good purposes toward the vessels of His grace until the time for final judgment is right (Deut. 32:35; Ps. 37:7-13; 73:12-20; Rom. 9:22-23; I Pet. 3:20; II Pet. 3:9-15). In time, the reprobate wicked remain under God's curse and wrath, being hardened so that they harden themselves and heap up more judgment to themselves by their continued sins and impenitence (Ps. 69:20-28; John 3:36; Rom. 9:18).

But what does it mean then that God is patient and longsuffering in Himself eternally without respect to the creation? This is related to God's immutable faithfulness and impassibility. One who lacks patience becomes weary, upset and restless (Job 10:1; Ps. 69:3; Isa. 57:20-21; Matt. 6:30-32; James 5:11). In contrast, God is eternally and unchangeably full of perfect peace and never

grows weary (Isa. 26:3; 40:28; II Cor. 13:11). God's love is, therefore, patient and longsuffering so that all the temporary incompleteness in the outworking of all His purposes in time cannot affect or change His love (I Cor. 13:8-13; I John 4:12). God's love is never weary in Himself through all eternity and prevents weariness in its object. Also God's love is full of peace according to which peace is bestowed upon the object of His love and perfect peace is enjoyed in the bond of mutual love.

Finally, God is full of joy, gladness and delight (Rom. 14:17; I Thess. 1:6). God's joyful love, therefore, takes delight in the delightful and joyous object of His love, and bestows joy and gladness so that God rejoices over His beloved (Isa. 62:4-5; 65:17-19; Zeph. 3:17). Considering what God's love is in Himself, it should be very apparent that there is no possibility for the kind of imperfect, weak, lesser love that is advocated by the universalists. Instead of entertaining such philosophical fantasies, we ought to know God from His Word, and so adore and worship Him for His revelation of Himself to us in Jesus Christ.

So far in this discourse, we have mostly treated the object of God's love in abstract and hypothetical terms, although we have said that the object of God's love in Himself must be Himself. To avoid any unworthy misconception of God's love, as if it were inherently selfish, self-centred or narcissistic, we must treat it in connection with how it is revealed in the Holy Trinity. We should see why, for example, the monad of the Muslims is not and cannot be essentially love. In our next editorial, we will consider how God's love is revealed in relation to His names and His works, especially in the Holy Trinity, but also with respect to the creation and His church (DV).

God's Saving Will in the New Testament (1)

Rev. Angus Stewart

Introduction

Our title, “God’s Saving Will in the *New Testament*,” deliberately limits the field.¹ We are not going to look at God’s saving will in the Old Testament, except by way of passing references; otherwise there would be too much material to treat here. We will especially focus on two Greek verbs for the activity of willing: *theloo* and *boulomai* (and their cognates), which occur in the New Testament about 270 times and about 50 times, respectively.²

Dietrich Müller’s analysis of what can and cannot be said regarding the different shades of meaning of these two Greek words is reflective of modern biblical scholarship:

A clear terminological distinction between *boulomai* (originally volition as a mental act) and *thelō* (originally instinctive desire) is no longer possible after the very early overlap of the areas covered by the words and is excluded by the time of the NT [i.e., New Testament] by their largely synonymous usage.³

However, the old nuances are there in the first instance of *theloo* and the first instance of *boulomai*, with both Greek verbs occurring in the same verse which occurs very near the start of the New Testament, even in its first chapter. After tracing our Lord’s genealogy back to King David and the patriarch Abraham (Matt. 1:1-17), and after stating that Joseph’s fiancée Mary is pregnant by the

¹ This article is a greatly developed and expanded version of a speech delivered in South Wales on 25 January, 2018: “God’s Saving Will in the New Testament” (www.cprc.co.uk/sermons/gods-saving-will-in-the-new-testament).

² Unless otherwise indicated, these two Greek words underlie the italicized words in New Testament quotations in these articles, such as “will,” “would,” “counsel,” “pleasure,” “list,” “desire,” “wish,” “voluntary,” “disposed” and even “forward.”

³ Dietrich Müller, “Will, Purpose,” in Colin Brown (gen. ed.), *The New International Dictionary of New Testament Theology*, vol. 3 (USA: Zondervan, 1978), p. 1015.

Holy Spirit (v. 18), just two verses into the narrative, we read, “Then Joseph her husband, being a just man, and not *willing* [*theloo*] to make her a publick example, was *minded* [*boulomai*] to put her away privily” (v. 19). In other words, because he did not want or desire (*theloo*) to embarrass Mary publicly, Joseph decided or resolved (*boulomai*) to break their engagement quietly.

Theologically, the will of the Triune God has historically and helpfully been spoken of in two main ways:

1. God’s will of decree—what He has sovereignly decided to do. This is God’s eternal and immutable counsel which determines absolutely everything that has happened or shall come to pass.
2. God’s will of command—what He tells man he should do. This is God’s moral and ethical standard for us revealing His holy requirements from us, which are summarized in the Ten Commandments.

Below is a fine quote from the authoritative entry in *The Theological Dictionary of the New Testament* on *theloo* or *thelein*, the Greek word used most often in the New Testament to refer to God’s will. The passage speaks first of God’s will of decree and then His will of command:

- [1] God’s *thelein* [will] is always characterised by absolute definiteness, sovereign self-assurance and efficacy. It is resolute and complete willing ... it refers either to the divine will in creation (I C[or]. 12:18; 15:38) or to the divine sovereignty in disposing to salvation ([John] 3:8 of the Spirit in regeneration ...) ... it denotes the independent and self-efficacious power of disposal in the hands of God, who is a free to do what He wills with His own. In R[omans] 9:18, 22 Paul shows how the *thelein* [will] of free and sovereign disposal is declared in the event of salvation. It finds expression as a demonstration of wrath and power both in having mercy and in hardening ...
- [2] Other statements with reference to God use *thelein* [will] to denote that which God requires of the righteous. In this respect there is recurrent reference (M[at].t. 9:13; 12:7; H[e]

b. 10:5, 8) to the prophetic statement that God requires *eleos* [mercy] and not *thusia* [sacrifice] (Hos. 6:6; [Ps.] 39:6 [Hebrew = 40:6 English]).⁴

This powerful statement describes well God's will of decree: "always characterized by absolute definiteness, sovereign self-assurance and efficacy ... resolute and complete willing ... the independent and self-efficacious power of disposal ... [so that God is] free to do what He wills with His own," etc. After describing [1] Jehovah's will of decree, the quote mentions [2] His will of command, what He "requires" of us.

There are several interrelated purposes of this article on "God's Saving Will in the New Testament." First, it will show us that God's will, especially His saving will, is a massive theme in the New Testament revelation, as well as in the Scriptures generally. There are many texts on the saving will of God or Christ or the Holy Spirit. References to the will of the Trinity or the wills of believers (which it graciously renews) or the wills of the wicked (to which it is in moral opposition) are found in every one of the 27 books of the New Testament, whether history, epistle or apocalypse. The subject of the will appears in parables, miracles and controversies; it is presented in doctrinal discourses, ethical passages and moving doxologies; and it occurs in connection with the believer's duty, the church's calling and the Saviour's cross. It is a rich field to survey and enjoy!

Second, it will set forth Jehovah's amazing control and government of the universe, and especially His gracious salvation of His church in the Lord Jesus.

Third, it will expose both the falsity and the poverty of the well-meant offer, the notion that the Almighty earnestly and fervently wills, wishes, wants and desires the salvation of those whom He eternally and immutably reprobated. This strange doctrine presents the ghastly spectre of a failing, foolish and frustrated god. It will be refuted at appropriate places in this article and the whole of the Appendix will be devoted to this subject.

Fourth, it will strengthen our faith in the absolutely sovereign God of heaven

⁴ Gottlob Schrenk, "*theloo, theleema, theleesis*," in Gerhard Kittel (ed.), *Theological Dictionary of the New Testament*, trans. and ed. Geoffrey W. Bromiley, vol. 3 (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1965), pp. 47-48. In article titles and quotes from Schrenk, I have transliterated the Greek.

and earth, our confidence in His wholly gracious salvation, and our comfort in the all-wise and all-powerful will of God in our Lord Jesus Christ.

Fifth, it will teach us our glorious calling as Jehovah's servants "both to *will* and to do of his good pleasure" (Phil. 2:13).

God's Will in Ephesians 1:1-14

Let us start by considering Ephesians 1:1-14, paying special attention to the words and phrases that are *italicized* or **emboldened**:

1 Paul, an apostle of Jesus Christ by the *will* of God, to the saints which are at Ephesus, and to the faithful in Christ Jesus: 2 grace be to you, and peace, from God our Father, and from the Lord Jesus Christ. 3 Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who hath blessed us with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ: 4 according as he hath **chosen** us in him before the foundation of the world, that we should be holy and without blame before him in love: 5 having **predestinated** us unto the adoption of children by Jesus Christ to himself, according to the **good pleasure** of his *will*, 6 to the praise of the glory of his grace, wherein he hath made us accepted in the beloved. 7 in whom we have redemption through his blood, the forgiveness of sins, according to the riches of his grace; 8 wherein he hath abounded toward us in all wisdom and prudence; 9 having made known unto us the mystery of his *will*, according to his **good pleasure** which he hath **purposed** in himself: 10 that in the dispensation of the fulness of times he might gather together in one all things in Christ, both which are in heaven, and which are on earth; even in him: 11 in whom also we have obtained an inheritance, being **predestinated** according to the **purpose** of him who worketh all things after the **counsel** of his own *will*: 12 that we should be to the praise of his glory, who first trusted in Christ. 13 in whom ye also trusted, after that ye heard the word of truth, the gospel of your salvation: in whom also

after that ye believed, ye were sealed with that holy Spirit of promise, *14* which is the earnest of our inheritance until the redemption of the purchased possession, unto the praise of his glory.

This familiar and beautiful passage refers to God's "will" of decree four times (vv. 1, 5, 9, 11)—italicized (above). We also have five closely related words or phrases: God's "good pleasure" (vv. 5, 9) or "purpose" (vv. 9, 11) or "counsel" (v. 11), as well as the "predestination" of God's people (vv. 5, 11) or our eternal election or being "chosen" in Christ (v. 4)—emboldened (above). These six key terms are found 12 times in the first 14 verses of Ephesians 1. Sometimes three or even four of these crucial words or phrases are heaped together in one verse, as in verses 5, 9 and 11. The apostle is using weighty theological terms that sharpen and reinforce each other in order to build an unassailable case regarding God's saving will in Jesus Christ.

We can distinguish different shades of meaning in the four references to God's "will" in Ephesians 1. First, in verse 11, we have the great truth that our heavenly Father "worketh all things after the counsel of his own *will*." This is God's all-encompassing will of decree that excludes nothing and includes everything in His creation.⁵

Second, in speaking of our legal inclusion in His family, verse 5 brings God's *saving* will into sharper focus: "God predestinated us unto the adoption of children by Jesus Christ to himself, according to the good pleasure of his *will*."

Third, Ephesians 1 declares the oneness of the eschatological catholic or universal church of Christ: the totality of elect Jews and Gentiles in the new creation in the age to come. God has

made known unto us the mystery of his *will*, according to the good pleasure which he hath purposed in himself: that in the dispensation of the fulness of times he might gather together in one all things in Christ, both which are in heaven, and which are on earth; even in him (vv. 9-10).

⁵ This includes the life, death, burial and decomposition of Jesse's youngest son: "For David, after he had served his own generation by the *will* of God, fell on sleep, and was laid unto his fathers, and saw corruption" (Acts 13:36).

Fourth, the very first verse of Ephesians mentions the will of God in its reference to Paul's office and ministry in the church: "Paul, an apostle of Jesus Christ by the *will* of God" (v. 1; cf. I Cor. 1:1; II Cor. 1:1; Col. 1:1; II Tim. 1:1). He preached and served the saving purpose of God in the first century, and, by his inspired epistles, he teaches and extols that salvific will to the whole church throughout the last days until our Lord's second coming.

These two spheres of God's will of decree—His all-encompassing will that embraces the whole universe and His saving will regarding His elect in Jesus Christ—are, of course, intimately related. Ephesians 1:11 states that we are "predestinated according to the purpose of him who worketh all things after the counsel of his own *will*." Thus God's saving will in delivering us from our sin and misery is served by His all-encompassing will.

Likewise, Christ taught that the Father has "given him power over all flesh, that he should give eternal life to as many as thou hast given him" (John 17:2). Thus "we know that all things [in the all-encompassing will of God] work together for good to them that love God, to them who are the called according to his [saving] purpose" (Rom. 8:28).

Ephesians 1 refers to God's will in relationship to eternity—eternity past, so to speak—and time. God's will is eternal because we were "chosen" or elected in Christ "before the foundation of the world" (v. 4). God's eternal will of decree, both in our election and with respect to absolutely everything in His creation, is perfectly effected in history, because He "worketh all things" in space and time "after the counsel of his own *will*" (v. 11). Therefore, God's all-encompassing counsel or plan, His will of decree or good pleasure, is realized in an equally all-embracing providence so that He does in time exactly what He willed in eternity (Ps. 115:3; 135:6; Isa. 14:24-27; 46:10; Dan. 4:35). This all-encompassing decree, effected in an all-encompassing providence, serves the salvation of all of the elect through the crucified and risen Christ.

God's saving will, the apostle teaches in Ephesians 1:1-14, is Trinitarian. Consider even the structure of the passage. After Paul's address to the Ephesians (vv. 1-2), he speaks especially of the role of the Father in our salvation (vv. 3-6). In verses 7-12, Christ, the eternal Son incarnate who redeemed us from our sins, is in the foreground. Then the Holy Spirit is presented as the

seal and down payment of our salvation (vv. 13-14). Thus God's redemptive will—in its conception in eternity, its accomplishment at the cross, and its application to us in this world and the next—is Trinitarian: of the Father, through the Son and by the Holy Spirit.

Schrenk ably sets forth "the counsel of his own *will*" (v. 11) as the eternal source and driving force of the church's gracious salvation in Ephesians 1:1-14:

In the magnifying of the divine economy of salvation in Eph. 1, which is shot through with references to the will of God ... the expositions of the foreordination and election of the community within a Christological universalism which embraces both heaven and earth (v. 10), lead finally to a solemn climax in the statement (v. 11): ["in whom also we have obtained an inheritance, being predestinated according to the purpose of him who worketh all things after the counsel of his own *will*"]. The inheritance of the community, which consists in the final revelation and has its provisional seal in the Spirit ... is rooted in [God's predestinating purpose]. Everything is mediated and present once and for all in Christ ... and everything finally derives from the ["counsel of his own *will*"] which finally effects the whole fulness of the event of salvation. It is quite plain that this ["counsel of his own *will*"] has the final word, that it not merely overarches the [election] (v. 4), [predestination] (v. 5, 11) and ["purpose"] (v. 11), but that it also sets in movement everything which in this whole section is described as the grace present in Christ and granted to the community as the reality of salvation. This helps us to see that in the formula "counsel of his will" the inflexible ordination of His will finds a full-orbed pleonastic expression.⁶

How must we, the objects and beneficiaries of God's saving will, respond, especially as we grasp more and more of its riches? First, we worship the Triune God. At the end of the sections on the Father (vv. 3-6), the Son (vv. 7-12) and

⁶ Gottlob Schrenk, "*boulomai, boulee, bouleema*," in Gerhard Kittel (ed.), *Theological Dictionary of the New Testament*, trans. and ed. Geoffrey W. Bromiley, vol. 1 (Grand Rapids, MI: Eerdmans, 1964), pp. 635-636.

the Spirit (vv. 13-14), we have some form of the statement that our salvation is all “to the praise of his glory” (vv. 6, 12, 14). Second, we bless God: “Blessed be the God and Father of our Lord Jesus Christ, who hath blessed us with all spiritual blessings in heavenly places in Christ: according as he hath chosen [or elected] us in him before the foundation of the world” (vv. 3-4).

We praise and bless God! That is the practical goal and result for Christ’s children in studying God’s saving will, especially as it is set forth in Ephesians 1!

God’s Will in Romans 9:6-24

Having considered God’s will in Ephesians 1:1-14, we now turn to our second major passage on this wonderful subject, Romans 9:6-24:

6 Not as though the word of God hath taken none effect. For they are not all Israel, which are of Israel: 7 neither, because they are the seed of Abraham, are they all children: but, In Isaac shall thy seed be called. 8 That is, They which are the children of the flesh, these are not the children of God: but the children of the promise are counted for the seed. 9 For this is the word of promise, At this time will I come, and Sara shall have a son. 10 And not only this; but when Rebecca also had conceived by one, even by our father Isaac; 11 (for the children being not yet born, neither having done any good or evil, that the purpose of God according to election might stand, not of works, but of him that calleth;) 12 it was said unto her, The elder shall serve the younger. 13 As it is written, Jacob have I loved, but Esau have I hated. 14 What shall we say then? Is there unrighteousness with God? God forbid. 15 For he saith to Moses, I will have mercy on whom I will have mercy, and I will have compassion on whom I will have compassion. 16 So then it is not of him that *willeth*, nor of him that *runneth*, but of God that sheweth mercy. 17 For the scripture saith unto Pharaoh, Even for this same purpose have I raised thee up, that I might shew my power in thee, and that my name might be declared throughout all the earth. 18

Therefore hath he mercy on whom he *will* have mercy, and whom he *will* he hardeneth. 19 Thou wilt say then unto me, Why doth he yet find fault? For who hath resisted his *will*? 20 Nay but, O man, who art thou that repliest against God? Shall the thing formed say to him that formed it, Why hast thou made me thus? 21 Hath not the potter power over the clay, of the same lump to make one vessel unto honour, and another unto dishonour? 22 What if God, *willing* to shew his wrath, and to make his power known, endured with much longsuffering the vessels of wrath fitted to destruction: 23 and that he might make known the riches of his glory on the vessels of mercy, which he had afore prepared unto glory 24 even us, whom he hath called, not of the Jews only, but also of the Gentiles?

Like Ephesians 1, Romans 9 refers frequently to Jehovah's will: *theloo* or *boulomai* (or their cognates). It is mentioned four times in the three verses below from this great chapter of Scripture:

Therefore hath he mercy on whom he *will* have mercy, and whom he *will* he hardeneth (v. 18).

Thou wilt say then unto me, Why doth he yet find fault? For who hath resisted his *will*? (v. 19).

What if God, *willing* to shew his wrath, and to make his power known, endured with much longsuffering the vessels of wrath fitted to destruction ...? (v. 22).

Whereas Ephesians 1 speaks only of God's will in election, Romans 9 deals with His will in both election and reprobation. Election, of course, is God's eternal, sovereign and unconditional choice of certain people in Jesus Christ, both to grace and to glory, to the honour of His name alone. Reprobation, on the other hand, is God's eternal, sovereign and unconditional purpose to pass by and ordain to destruction all others, in the way of their sins, to the praise of His holy justice.

Election and reprobation go hand-in-hand with God's love and God's hatred respectively: "Jacob have I loved, but Esau have I hated" (v. 13). In the

context of Romans 9, the covenant God is saying, in effect, “Elect Jacob have I loved and reprobate Esau have I hated.”

Election and reprobation also go hand-in-hand with God’s mercy and God’s hardening respectively: “Therefore hath he mercy on whom he *will* have mercy [i.e., the elect], and whom he *will* he hardeneth [i.e., the reprobate]” (v. 18).

Putting it all together, there is one people embraced in God’s election, God’s love and God’s mercy. There is also God’s reprobation, God’s hatred and God’s hardening of others.

These two realities, hatred and hardening, are crucial aspects of the biblical and Reformed doctrine of reprobation. Divine reprobation entails divine hatred and divine hardening of those whom He passed by in His absolute sovereignty and ordained to destruction for their sins in His unassailable justice.

God’s saving will regarding His elect is not only served by His all-encompassing decree of providence (Eph. 1:11) but is also served by His rejecting will. That is, God’s election of some in Jesus Christ is served by His reprobation of others: “The elder [i.e., reprobate, hated Esau] shall serve the younger [i.e., elect, beloved Jacob]” (Rom. 9:12).

Both God’s will in election and His will in reprobation are irresistible, as the apostle teaches in his rhetorical question of Romans 9:19: “who hath resisted his *will*?” No one has or will for “none can stay his hand, or say unto him, What doest thou?” (Dan. 4:35).

Of course, objections to this biblical teaching always arise from unbelieving, proud man. The apostle brings them up and deals with them in Romans 9. Thus he writes, “What shall we say then? Is there unrighteousness with God?” The response? “God forbid,” literally, “May it not be!” (v. 14).

Paul anticipates another protest: “Thou wilt say then unto me, Why doth he yet find fault? For who hath resisted his *will*?” (v. 19). The apostle counters,

Nay but, O man, who art thou that repliest against God? Shall the thing formed say to him that formed it, Why hast thou made me thus? Hath not the potter power over the clay, of the same lump to make one vessel unto honour, and another unto dishonour? (vv. 20-21).

The former Pharisee makes it clear that his inspired teaching in Romans 9 is in full accord with the Old Testament Scriptures on God's will in election and reprobation. In the space of only eleven verses (vv. 7-17), Paul quotes the first two books of the Pentateuch as many as five times.

First, he provides three citations from Genesis, with the last two prefaced by introductory remarks: "In Isaac shall thy seed be called" (Rom. 9:7; Gen. 21:12); "For this is the word of promise, At this time will I come, and Sara shall have a son" (Rom. 9:9; Gen. 18:10, 14); "it was said unto her, The elder shall serve the younger" (Rom. 9:12; Gen. 25:23).

Second, Paul uses quotation formulas before citing two verses from Exodus: "For he [i.e., God] saith to Moses, I will have mercy on whom I will have mercy, and I will have compassion on whom I will have compassion" (Rom. 9:15; Ex. 33:19); "For the scripture saith unto Pharaoh, Even for this same purpose have I raised thee up, that I might shew my power in thee, and that my name might be declared throughout all the earth" (Rom. 9:17; Ex. 9:16).

Romans 9:6-24 quotes not only the first two scriptural books, Genesis and Exodus, but also the last book of the Old Testament, as is arranged in our Bibles, Malachi: "As it is written, Jacob have I loved, but Esau have I hated" (Rom. 9:13; Mal. 1:2-3).

Clearly, the doctrine of the apostle to the Gentiles in Romans 9:6-24 regarding God's will in sovereign election and reprobation is divinely authoritative. It fits with, and unpacks, six Old Testament texts: five from Moses, in Genesis and Exodus, and one from Malachi. Moreover, Romans 9, like all of Scripture, consists of words breathed forth by the Holy Spirit (II Tim. 3:16), who was sent by the ascended Lord Jesus Christ, the revelation of the Triune God.

This authoritative teaching in Romans 9:6-24 refutes two common errors. First, it condemns man's free will, the Arminian heresy that man is able to choose God and His salvation with the help of an alleged resistible divine grace. The biblical and Reformed faith boldly proclaims the holy God's free will in both election and reprobation, not totally depraved *man's* free will! Paul explicitly draws this conclusion: "So then it [i.e., salvation] is not of him that *willeth* [i.e., man and his supposed free will], nor of him that *runneth* [i.e., man and his works, even his most strenuous religious exertions], but of God that sheweth mercy" (v. 16).

Second, Romans 9 exposes the well-meant offer of the gospel, that is, the idea that God earnestly desires to save absolutely all men head-for-head or everyone who hears the gospel (including the reprobate). This is a position that is intrinsic to Roman Catholic and Arminian soteriology, but it is now promoted by many in Reformed and Presbyterian circles as if it were the biblical and Reformed gospel.

However, Romans 9 actually states the exact opposite. It is not merely that God does *not* earnestly want to save the reprobate but, instead, He earnestly wills and desires—and this has to be said reverently because it is a fearful thing—to punish the wicked for their sins.

It is not that God delights in hurting people (Eze. 33:11), but rather that He wills to reveal His own infinite holiness and omnipotence in punishing the impenitent as they justly deserve. This is what Romans 9 clearly says, “What if God, *willing* [i.e., wishing, desiring, wanting] to shew his wrath, and to make his power known, endured with much longsuffering the vessels of wrath fitted to destruction ...?” (v. 22).

This is the true and sincere desire of God—a desire which He always fulfils!—in accordance with His unchangeable will of decree in reprobation. It is the exact opposite of what is claimed to be scriptural and Reformed teaching and preaching by many in our day.

Finally, it is striking that Romans 9’s theodicy or justification of God in election and reprobation is stated in terms of God’s *will* concerning salvation, both with regard to whom He wills or wishes or wants or desires to save in Jesus Christ and whom He wills or wishes or wants or desires not to save.

What if God, *willing* to shew his wrath, and to make his power known, endured with much longsuffering the vessels of wrath fitted to destruction: and that he might make known the riches of his glory on the vessels of mercy, which he had afore prepared unto glory even us, whom he hath called, not of the Jews only, but also of the Gentiles? (vv. 22-24).

Clearly, the Bible’s own inspired theodicy or justification of God’s decree of election and reprobation in Romans 9 includes the truth that He wills or desires to glorify Himself by the manifestation of His justice and omnipotence

in punishing those whom He has eternally ordained to destruction. So how can advocates of the well-meant offer, who claim that He desires to save the reprobate, properly defend the absolute sovereignty of God, truly explain the coherence of biblical theology and faithfully exegete this great chapter?

The Will of the Triune God

So far we have treated two major Scripture passages, Ephesians 1:1-14 and Romans 9:6-24, on God's will. Now we are going to consider the will of the Triune God in several texts in the New Testament.

The elders in heaven utter this doxology regarding Jehovah's will in creation: "Thou art worthy, O Lord, to receive glory and honour and power: for thou hast created all things, and for thy *pleasure* they are and were created" (Rev. 4:11). The origin and occurrences of the universe do not lie with eternal matter or a cosmic explosion or pitiless evolution or remorseless fate or blind chance or any other idol vainly forged by futile man. The source and government of all things rests in the personal will of the Triune God. Jehovah created and rules everything to honour Himself and for His pleasure!

Not just the whole vast creation, but even the nature and form of all kinds of tiny plant seeds are determined by the sovereign will of the Almighty: "God giveth it a body as it hath *pleased* him, and to every seed his own body" (I Cor. 15:38). It is not due to time and chance or millions of years of evolution after a gigantic explosion; it is the will of the Most High that determines the shape and size of the seeds of all the types of vegetation!

Jehovah's will is sovereign not only in natural things but also in salvation. In the parable of the vineyard, the Triune God, portrayed as "the lord of the vineyard" (Matt. 20:8), asks, "Is it not lawful for me to do what I *will* with mine own?" (v. 15). Our Father in heaven explains that His unconditional decree of election is determinative in salvation: "for many be called [i.e., externally in the preaching], but few chosen" (v. 16). As the sovereign Lord, He has the right to do whatever He wills or wishes or wants, including in eternal predestination!

Robert Godfrey explains God's unconditional choice of some to salvation in Christ according to His good pleasure or will:

Election is grounded on what God finds in Himself, not on what He finds or anticipates in us. God's good pleasure, that is, the purpose that pleases Him, is the motive of His plan. This reality ensures that God receives all the glory for salvation and that we are appropriately humbled before Him.⁷

What about regeneration, the first element in the application of God's salvation in Jesus Christ? John 1:13 states that elect sinners are "born [again], not of blood, nor of the *will* of the flesh, nor of the *will* of man, but of God." No one has been, or ever will be, regenerated by his own will or by the will of another human being, whether it is the will of their minister or parents or neighbours. Instead, the new birth comes solely by the will or desire of the blessed Trinity!

James 1:18 teaches the same God-exalting truth: "Of his own *will* begat he us with the word of truth." Moreover, Jehovah and His desires are absolutely unchangeable: "Every good gift and every perfect gift is from above, and cometh down from the Father of lights, with whom is no variableness, neither shadow of turning" (v. 17).

What is Jehovah's saving will regarding the regenerate "little ones which believe in" Jesus (Matt. 18:6)? Our Redeemer teaches us, "it is not the *will* of your Father which is in heaven, that one of these little ones should perish" (v. 14). Since God does not wish or desire the eternal destruction of any of His elect lambs or straying sheep (vv. 12-13), their spiritual preservation in this life and everlasting blessedness in the next are divinely guaranteed!

Hebrews 6:17 declares that our heavenly Father

willing more abundantly to shew unto the heirs of promise the immutability [or unchangeableness] of his counsel, confirmed it by an oath: that by two immutable things, in which it was impossible for God to lie, we might have a strong consolation, who have fled for refuge to lay hold upon the hope set before us.

These "two immutable things" are Jehovah's promise (v. 13) and oath (vv.

⁷ W. Robert Godfrey, *Saving the Reformation: The Pastoral Theology of the Canons of Dort* (York, PA: Reformation Trust Publishing, 2019), p. 93.

13-14, 16-17). By nature, the true and faithful God cannot lie. By adding His promise and oath, He shows that He “more abundantly” wills and earnestly desires that His people know that His “counsel,” decree or purpose to bless us is absolutely unchangeable (v. 14)!

In the age of the new covenant, the Triune God desires to, and does, reveal the mystery of the catholic or universal church of Jews and Gentiles through their union with the Lord Jesus:

the mystery which hath been hid from ages and from generations, but now is made manifest to his saints: to whom God *would* make known what is the riches of the glory of this mystery among the Gentiles; which is Christ in you, the hope of glory (Col. 1:26-27).

In the first century, our heavenly Father gave supernatural miracles and spiritual gifts through the apostles in the service of the gospel: “God also bearing them witness, both with signs and wonders, and with divers miracles, and gifts of the Holy Ghost, according to his own *will*” (Heb. 2:4).

The Triune God also wills to judge His professing people (and the ungodly world): “Therefore is the kingdom of heaven likened unto a certain king, which would take account of his servants” (Matt. 18:23), punishing the wicked by delivering them in His wrath to the “tormentors” (v. 34).

Over against the absolute sovereignty of God, we learn of “the pseudo-sovereignty of the Satanic claim” during our Lord’s temptation in the wilderness:⁸ “the devil said unto him, All this power will I give thee, and the glory of them: for that is delivered unto me; and to whomsoever I *will* I give it” (Luke 4:6).

Now let us move from the Triune God’s will of decree to His will of command. The Gospel According to Matthew records Jesus twice quoting Hosea 6:6 to the self-righteous Pharisees:

But go ye and learn what that meaneth, I *will* have mercy, and not sacrifice: for I am not come to call the righteous, but sinners to repentance (9:13).

⁸ Schrenk, “*theloo, theleema, theleesis*,” p. 48.

But if ye had known what this meaneth, I *will* have mercy, and not sacrifice, ye would not have condemned the guiltless (12:7).

The divine utterance, “I *will* have mercy, and not sacrifice,” refers to God’s will of command or preceptive will, not His will of decree, as Schrenk rightly states in a quote cited earlier:

Other statements with reference to God use *thelein* [will] to denote that which God *requires* of the righteous. In this respect there is recurrent reference (M[at]t. 9:13; 12:7; H[e]b. 10:5, 8) to the prophetic statement that God *requires* *eleos* [mercy] and not *thusia* [sacrifice] (Hos. 6:6; [Ps.] 39:6 [Hebrew = 40:6 English]).⁹

Both the Old Testament prophet, Hosea, and our chief prophet, the Lord Christ, are referring to the great calling of human beings to have, and show, mercy towards others.

This fits with the context in both Matthean passages. Jesus is wrongly rebuked by the Pharisees in the former for dining with infamous sinners and despised tax collectors, like Matthew himself, and in the latter for His disciples’ plucking heads of grain and eating them on the Sabbath.

As to the meaning of the aphorism itself, we note, first, that “I *will* have mercy, and not sacrifice” is a comparison, rather than an absolute statement. Behaving mercifully, a requirement of God’s moral law, is better than offering sacrifices, a requirement of God’s ceremonial law (I Sam. 15:22; cf. Jer. 7:22-23; Amos 5:21-24; Micah 6:8; Matt. 23:23-26; Mark 12:33). This is especially the case if the latter were not brought by the right people (true saints), from the right principle (faith) and to a right end (the glory of God).

Second, “I *will* have mercy, and not sacrifice” assures us of our Father’s moral approbation, delight and good pleasure in our Spirit-wrought obedience to His perceptive will in showing mercy to others (Rom. 12:2; Phil. 2:13; Col. 1:9-10).

Third, in so far as man’s being merciful to his neighbour is a divine *desire*, Jehovah’s irresistible grace affects such godly behaviour in the elect and regen-

⁹ Schrenk, “*theloo, theleema, theleesis*,” p. 48; italics mine.

erate members of Christ's body (Ps. 115:3; 135:6; Eph. 1:11).¹⁰ God's merciful saving will renews the wills of His people so that we show mercy to others.

John Calvin's comments on Matthew 9:13 are helpful:

That the statement, *I desired not sacrifice*, must be understood comparatively, is evident from the second clause [in the sentence by the son of Beeri], that *the knowledge of God is better than burnt-offerings* [Hos. 6:6]. By these words he [i.e., Hosea] does not absolutely reject [the Old Testament] *burnt-offerings*, but places them in a rank inferior to piety and faith. We ought to hold, that faith and spiritual worship are in themselves *pleasing* to God, and that charity and the duties of humanity towards our neighbours are in themselves required; but that *sacrifices* are but appendages, so to speak, which are of no value or estimation, where substantial truth is not found ... It ought to be observed that there is a synecdoche in the word *mercy*: for under one head the prophet embraces all the kindness which we owe to our brethren.¹¹

Luke 7:29-30 states,

And all the people that heard him [i.e., John the Baptist], and the publicans, justified God, being baptized with the baptism of John. But the Pharisees and lawyers rejected the *counsel* of God against themselves, being not baptized of him.

Here "the *counsel* of God" refers to Jehovah's preceptive will, yet not as a summary of man's duty towards his neighbour, as in the passages we just considered (Hos. 6:6; Matt. 9:13; 12:7), but specifically regarding the ministry of John the Baptist.

On the one hand, the common or "unlearned" people and the notorious tax collectors believed John's message of the soon-coming Messiah, repented of their sins and received the ordinance of baptism. Thus they "justified God,"

¹⁰ Notice that the text does not present God as saying, "I earnestly desire that *every single human being, including the reprobate*, shows mercy."

¹¹ John Calvin, *Commentary on a Harmony of the Evangelists, Matthew, Mark, and Luke*, trans. William Pringle (Grand Rapids, MI: Baker, repr. 1993), vol. 1, p. 403; italics mine.

that is, they declared Him righteous in His will and works and ways (Luke 7:29). On the other hand, the Jewish religious leaders spurned John's preaching concerning the kingdom of God and so refused to be baptized with water by him. Their gross disobedience was to their terrible disadvantage in time and eternity (v. 30).

I Timothy 2:4

In the history of the New Testament church, over the sixteen centuries from the Pelagian controversy to the present day, I Timothy 2:4 has been the most prominent text urged in support of the false doctrine that Almighty God earnestly wishes or passionately desires to save absolutely all human beings, including the reprobate. Hence it is worth taking more time with this verse than the preceding texts in the section on "The Will of the Triune God."

I Timothy 2:4 states that Jehovah "*will* have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth." Advocates of the well-meant offer wrongly interpret "all" men here to refer to everybody head for head.

Our first argument against this position involves the link between I Timothy 2:4 and its succeeding context (vv. 5-6):

[God] *will* have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth. For there is one God, and one mediator between God and men, the man Christ Jesus; who gave himself a ransom for all, to be testified in due time (vv. 4-6).

Logically, there are four—and only four—options regarding the interpretation of the word "all" in verses 4 and 6, and the resulting doctrines.

- [1] "All" in verses 4 and 6 means absolutely everybody, resulting in the well-meant offer and universal atonement.
- [2] "All" in verse 4 means absolutely everybody but "all" in verse 6 refers to (the elect of) all kinds or sorts of people, resulting in the well-meant offer and particular atonement.
- [3] "All" in verse 4 speaks of (the elect of) all kinds or sorts of people but "all" in verse 6 means absolutely everybody, resulting in God's effectual saving desire and universal atonement.

[4] "All" in verses 4 and 6 refers to (the elect of) all kinds or sorts of people, resulting in God's effectual saving desire and particular atonement.

Theologically, [3] is incoherent, and I know of no one who believes both that God effectually desires to save the elect alone and that He sent His only begotten Son to die for the sins of everyone head for head. [1] is consistent Arminianism: God wants to save everybody and so Christ died to try to save everybody. [4] is consistent Calvinism: God effectually desires to save all His sheep out of every kindred, tribe, tongue and nation, and so Jesus shed His precious blood for all of them. [2] is an amalgam of Arminianism (an ineffectual divine desire to save the reprobate) and Calvinism (particular atonement).

Textually, the position of those who call themselves Calvinists and hold to the well-meant offer [2] is excluded. I Timothy 2 explains why God "*will have all men to be saved*" (v. 4): "*For there is ... one mediator between [the one] God and men, the man Christ Jesus; who gave himself a ransom for all*" (vv. 5-6). If the "all" in verse 4 refers to absolutely everyone, it has the same meaning in verse 6. That is, if the "all" whom God desires to save is every human being head for head (v. 4), then the "all" for whom Christ died is every human being head for head (v. 6). In other words, if I Timothy 2:4 teaches the well-meant offer, then it leads to the heretical doctrine of universal atonement in verse 6! This is something that professed Calvinists should seriously consider, before swiftly drawing back from the Arminian abyss (cf. *Canons II*)! The fact that the "all" in both verse 4 and verse 6 refers to the same group provides textual support for [4] as the correct interpretation.

Our second argument looks not at the succeeding context but at I Timothy 2:4 itself: God "*will have all men* [1] *to be saved, and* [2] *to come unto the knowledge of the truth.*" The two things that Jehovah is here said to desire are essentially one. In fact, I Timothy 2:4 contains a hendiadys, that is, [1] through [2]. In other words, the Lord wants to save "all men" *through* their coming to the knowledge of the truth.

By any reasonable analysis, if God really desires everyone to come to the (saving) knowledge of the truth, He is making a very poor job of it. After all, in the history of the world, only a minority of people have ever heard the gospel even once. In Old Testament days, only the Jews received God's

verbal revelation (Ps. 147:19-20; Rom. 3:2). Even in the first 1,500 years of the New Testament era, the gospel was largely confined to the Mediterranean area or northern Europe. Is it really credible that the Most High passionately wants everyone head for head to come to the knowledge of the truth of His crucified and exalted Son, yet He has not even brought the preaching of His Word to most of them?

In our third argument, we move from the succeeding context of I Timothy 2:4 and the text itself to the preceding verses, which exhort us to pray, and express our gratitude, to God for civil rulers:

I exhort therefore, that, first of all, supplications, prayers, intercessions, and giving of thanks, be made for all men; for kings, and for all that are in authority; that we may lead a quiet and peaceable life in all godliness and honesty. For this is good and acceptable in the sight of God our Saviour; who *will* have all men to be saved, and to come unto the knowledge of the truth (vv. 1-4).

Have you prayed today for a politician or king or anyone in a position of civil authority? You might think, “What’s the point? They are trapped in a politically-correct system where it is almost impossible for them to believe in Jesus Christ and live unto Him within that ungodly framework.”

Yet consider Paul’s own day! The Roman Empire in which he lived was the fourth beast of Daniel 7. Under its auspices, the incarnate son of God had been crucified. Paul himself had been imprisoned multiple times by imperial authorities and he would later be martyred by the Roman state in its capital city on the Tiber.

Paul’s exhortation in I Timothy 2 is, Pray for all kinds of men, even kings and magistrates, because God wants to save all sorts of people, even pagan rulers, including those who persecute Christians (vv. 1-4). Among them too are those for whom our only mediator “gave himself a ransom” (vv. 5-6). The apostle gives another good reason for intercession for civil authorities: “that we may lead a quiet and peaceable life in all godliness and honesty” (v. 2).

Out of the many great theologians that he could have chosen, Jaroslav Pelikan mentions Augustine (354-430), Martin Bucer (1491-1551), John Calvin

(1509-1564) and Zacharias Ursinus (1534-1583) as interpreting I Timothy 2:4 in agreement with what has been set forth above:

Martin Bucer, to whose exegesis of the Pauline epistles Calvin acknowledged his indebtedness, followed Augustine's explanation that the saving will of God of which the passage spoke pertained not to individuals, but to classes of men. Ursinus, too, interpreted the passage to refer to "all classes" rather than to all individuals ... It was essential, according to Calvin, not to superimpose 1 Timothy 2:1-4 on the doctrine of predestination, but rather to read it in the light of "the term 'election,' [which] occurs so often in Scripture." Then it would be evident that "the apostle's meaning here is simply that no nation of the earth and no class of society is excluded from salvation." By any other interpretation, this command to pray for pagan kings and emperors, "an almost hopeless group of men," would be "absurd" on the face of it.¹²

After this examination of I Timothy 2:4 in its context, the Reformed man or woman responds, first, with a measure of holy relief: "It is good to see so clearly that I Timothy 2 does not teach either a failed desire of the Lord of glory to save everybody or the Arminian lie of universal atonement." Second, the apostle's exhortation regarding intercession and thanksgiving for civil magistrates often forces us to conclude, "I need to pray more for politicians for I have been sorely tempted to neglect this, since it must be so hard for civil rulers to trust in Jesus alone and operate as faithful saints in their environment."

II Peter 3:9

Besides I Timothy 2:4, II Peter 3:9 is a second New Testament text that is often cited as if it taught a frustrated desire of the Triune God to save everyone

¹² Jaroslav Pelikan, *The Christian Tradition: A History of the Development of Doctrine*, vol. 4: *Reformation of Church and Dogma (1300-1700)* (Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press, 1984), p. 237. The webpage of "Quotes on I Timothy 2:4" contains some 40 pages of comments from men in the patristic, mediaeval, Reformation and modern periods who oppose or do not agree with that exegesis of the verse that proposes an unrealized or unfulfilled desire in God to save the reprobate (www.cprc.co.uk/quotes/1timothy2v4).

head for head. The verse reads, “The Lord is not slack concerning his promise, as some men count slackness; but is longsuffering to us-ward, not *willing* that any should perish, but that all should come to repentance.”

But what one usually hears cited is only this bit: “The Lord is ... not *willing* that any should perish, but that all should come to repentance.” The “any” and “all” allegedly refer to absolutely everybody. Thus the well-meant offer claims that God does not wish or desire that a single person perish in hell. It is wrong, however, to take half a verse from the Bible and then run with it into strange theological positions, without even explaining it in its context.

First, what is the situation that II Peter 3 addressing? Some people denied that the Lord would ever return: “Where is the promise of his coming?” (v. 4). By the inspiration of the Spirit, the apostle explains why Jesus has not yet appeared, over against the “scoffers” and their arguments (vv. 3-4).

If Peter is teaching that Christ delayed His second coming because God is not willing that any individual human being should perish, as the well-meant offer teaches, the Lord is never going to come back, since everybody will never be saved. It is certain that not everybody has been saved in the past, not everybody is saved now and not everybody shall be saved in the future.

Thus Peter’s argument would reach the same conclusion as the scoffers: Christ is not returning. If He will not come back until He has saved everybody, then we are in for an interminably long wait! Some of the postmillennial Reconstructionists say that the last day might be tens of thousands or hundreds of thousands or millions of years away. The well-meant offer reading of II Peter 3:9 is even worse: There is no point looking, longing or praying for the Saviour’s second coming since He will *never* return!

Second, Peter exhorts believers to “account that the longsuffering of our Lord is salvation” (v. 15). All of those to whom God is longsuffering (v. 9) will certainly be saved, for “the longsuffering of our Lord is salvation” (v. 15). Peter instructs us that we are to “account” or reckon this as a first principle of the Christian religion!

Third, we should notice the word “usward” in the apostolic affirmation that “God is longsuffering to *usward*, not *willing* that any should perish.” Are we to think that God’s longsuffering is particular and always effectual (v. 15)

“to usward” (v. 9), that is, His “beloved” elect (1:10; 3:1, 8, 14, 17) in His “beloved Son” (1:17), but that, when the next clause in II Peter 3:9 states that He is “not willing that any should perish,” the word “any” is to be understood universally of each and every human being, most of whom eternally perish? No! God’s eternal love and irresistible longsuffering toward us, the predestinate, carries through the remainder of the verse: “But, beloved ... the Lord ... is longsuffering to us-ward, not *willing* that any [of us] should perish, but that all [of us] should come to repentance” (vv. 8-9).

At the end of his treatment of “The ‘All’ Passages,” to which Arminians frequently appeal, American Presbyterian Robert L. Reymond comments on II Peter 3:9 with appeal to a sixteenth-century French Reformed theologian, John Calvin, and a seventeenth-century British Congregationalist divine, John Owen (1616-1683).¹³

Finally, there is the statement of 2 Peter 3:9 which the universalist alleges also teaches a universal saving will in God: “[The Lord] is patient with you, because he does not want any to perish, but all to come to repentance.” Again, the contextual universe will allow no such conclusion. In 3:8 Peter addresses those to whom he is writing as “Beloved” [*agapetoi*], a term everywhere acknowledged to be a term for Christians or God’s elect. Then to them he says: “[The Lord] is patient with you” (referring to the Christians he is addressing), offering as his ground for this reassuring promise to these Christians the axiomatic truth: “because he does not want any [of you elect] to perish, but all [of you] to come to repentance.” Clearly the referent of his “any” is the Christian elect to whom he has been speaking and his “all” refers to the elect of God in their entirety; and his point is God’s concern for the church: the Lord, he says, is delaying his coming in order that he might bring the whole elect of God to repentance. To argue to the contrary, that is [as John Owen states in *The Death of Death*, p. 236], “to argue that because God would have none of those

¹³ Robert L. Reymond, *A New Systematic Theology of the Christian Faith* (Nashville, TN: Thomas Nelson Publishers, 1998), pp. 685-695.

to perish, but all of them to come to repentance, therefore he hath the same will and mind towards all and everyone in the world (even those to whom he never makes known his will, nor ever calls to repentance, if they never once hear of his way of salvation), comes not much short of extreme madness and folly” ... Calvin argues that what Peter means here is that God wills that those be saved whom he brings to repentance, and then he argues that God, in whose hand resides the authority to grant repentance, does not will to give repentance to all men without exception (*Institutes*, III.xxiv.16).¹⁴

To sum it all up, our Saviour cannot come back so long as there is even a single elect sheep who has not yet been effectually called, any more than the Almighty could have rained down fire and brimstone, a picture of hell, on Sodom while righteous Lot remained in that city or too near it (cf. Gen. 19:22; II Pet. 2:6-9; Jude 7). The full company of the elect, the whole body of Christ, must be regenerated and only then will the Lord return. All of those chosen in Jesus before the foundation of the world must be physically conceived and spiritually reborn before He can appear with great majesty to make all things new!

In light of all we have seen so far regarding the saving will of the blessed Trinity, we can agree wholeheartedly with this proposition of Jerome Zanchius (1516-1590): “The absolute will of God is the original spring and efficient cause of His people’s salvation.”¹⁵ The Italian Reformer gives this judicious explanation:

I say the original and efficient, for, *sensu complexo*, there are other intermediate causes of their salvation, which, however, all result from and are subservient to this primary one, the will of God. Such are His everlasting choice of them to eternal life—the eternal covenant of grace, entered into by the Trinity, in behalf of the elect; the incarnation, obedience, death

¹⁴ Reymond, *A New Systematic Theology*, p. 695. See “Quotes on II Peter 3:9” for some 18 pages of comments from many theological worthies (www.cprc.co.uk/quotes/2peter3v9).

¹⁵ Jerome Zanchius, *The Doctrine of Absolute Predestination*, trans. Augustus M. Toplady (London: Silver Trumpet Publications, repr. 1989), p. 23.

and intercession of Christ for them—all which are so many links in the great chain of causes, and not one of these can be taken away without marring and subverting the whole Gospel plan of salvation by Jesus Christ. We see, then, that the free, unbiassed, sovereign will of God is the root of this tree of life, which bears so many glorious branches and yields such salutary fruits: He therefore loved the elect and ordained them to life because He would; according to that of the apostle, “having predestinated us, according to the good pleasure of His will” (Eph. 1.5). Then, next after God’s covenant for His people and promises to them, comes in the infinite merit of Christ’s righteousness and atonement, for we were chosen to salvation in Him as members of His mystic body, and through Him, as our Surety and Substitute, by whose vicarious obedience to the moral law and submission to its curse and penalty, all we, whose names are in the book of life, should never incur the Divine hatred or be punished for our sins, but continue to eternity, as we were from eternity, heirs of God and joint-heirs with Christ. But still the Divine grace and favour (and God extends these to whom He will) must be considered as what gave birth to the glorious scheme of redemption, according to what our Lord Himself teaches us, “God so loved the world, that He gave His only-begotten Son,” etc. (John iii. 16), and that of the apostle, “In this was manifested the love of God towards us, because that He sent His only-begotten Son into the world, that we might live through Him” (1 John iv. 9).¹⁶

¹⁶ Zanchius, *The Doctrine of Absolute Predestination*, pp. 23-24. In an excellent section of this book, Zanchius states, defends and develops 14 theological propositions or “positions” regarding the will of God (pp. 12-25).

The Image of God and the Responsibility of Man

Samuel Watterson

Introduction

The *Westminster Shorter Catechism* begins by asking, “What is the chief end of man?” The answer highlights God’s purpose with the creation of man: man should “glorify God” and “enjoy him forever.” When Satan tempted Adam and Eve in the garden of Eden, it was this purpose of God which he intended to thwart. The catechism bases this conclusion on the fact that we have the *responsibility* to do all things to God’s glory (I Cor. 10:31) and that *all* things are for His glory (Rom. 11:36).

The clause “enjoy him for ever” makes it evident that the *Catechism* has in mind especially how the redeemed glorify God in new obedience (or how Adam glorified God before the Fall). God’s purposes are never thwarted and yet the reprobate wicked will not enjoy God. He has a different purpose with them, such as to display His power and just judgment (Rom. 9:22). This was God’s stated purpose with Pharaoh (Rom. 9:17). Nevertheless, as the *Catechism* emphasizes, God’s purpose with the elect is man’s *chief* end and, therefore, His purpose with the reprobate must serve that *chief* end. Isaiah presents God’s purpose with the elect as being especially created (or re-created in regeneration) for His glory: “Even every one that is called by my name: for I have created him for my glory, I have formed him; yea, I have made him” (Isa. 43:7).

The elect glorify God in a more direct and higher sense—in the sense for which man was ultimately and originally created. Other men will be *given* to serve this glorification of God by the elect: “Since thou wast precious in my sight, thou hast been honourable, and I have loved thee: therefore will I give men for thee, and people for thy life” (Isa. 43:4).

But, in contrast to the simple approach of the *Catechism*, when Scripture first presents man’s creation, we are shown more particularly *how* man was created to glorify God:

And God said, Let us make man in our image, after our likeness: and let them have dominion over the fish of the sea, and over the fowl of the air, and over the cattle, and over all the earth, and over every creeping thing that creepeth upon the earth. So God created man in his own image, in the image of God created he him; male and female created he them (Gen. 1:26-27).

God's purpose in man's original creation here is presented as man being made after the *image* or *likeness* of God. God's purposes do not change and, therefore, we may conclude that it is still God's purpose that man should glorify Him by being in His image. If we recognize that the *Catechism* is implying, in light of God's purpose, that all men have the *responsibility* "to glorify God, and enjoy him for ever," then, in light of His stated purpose at creation, we must likewise recognize the weighty responsibility of all men to bear the image of God. In this article, we will examine various parts of Scripture, often misunderstood and misapplied, which deal exactly with this responsibility.

Cursing and Lying

There are especially two passages in the New Testament which unequivocally refer to the Christian's responsibility with respect to the image of God in the regenerate. These are the verses that the Reformed confessions especially point to when referring to the image of God:

But now ye also put off all these; anger, wrath, malice, blasphemy, filthy communication out of your mouth. Lie not one to another, seeing that ye have put off the old man with his deeds; And have put on the new man, which is renewed in knowledge after the image of him that created him (Col. 3:8-10).

That ye put off concerning the former conversation the old man, which is corrupt according to the deceitful lusts; And be renewed in the spirit of your mind; And that ye put on the new man, which after God is created in righteousness and true holiness. Wherefore putting away lying, speak every man

truth with his neighbour: for we are members one of another (Eph. 4:22-25).

Much more could be quoted from these passages, for they teach us more about how we must walk according to the new man. But notice, first of all, that these implications for Christian living are derived especially from the consideration of how the new man is *after* God or *after* the image of Him. Second, notice that both passages refer to the creation of the new man. This is not referring to God's work of creation in Genesis 1 but to His work of re-creation, which we call regeneration (Eze. 36:25-27; II Cor. 5:17; Eph. 2:10). These two distinct works are similar in the sense that both involve creation in God's image. If regeneration in this image carries these responsibilities, man's original creation in God's image also carries these responsibilities.

Likewise, if the image of God in the new man consists in righteousness, true holiness and knowledge of God, so was this image in the original man. This is how the *Heidelberg Catechism* presents man's original creation after beginning to discuss the misery of fallen man:

Q. 6. Did God then create man so wicked and perverse?

A. By no means; but God created man good, and after His own image, in true righteousness and holiness, that he might rightly know God his Creator, heartily love Him, and live with Him in eternal happiness to glorify and praise Him.

Especially the second half of this answer is basically identical to the *Westminster Shorter Catechism*'s answer as to what man's chief end is. But here the *Heidelberg Catechism* connects God's purpose to man's original creation in God's image, referring to Genesis 1:26-27, Colossians 3:10 and Ephesians 4:24. This is instructive, since the *Heidelberg Catechism*, after speaking of the Fall, goes on to consider man's *responsibility* after the Fall.

Q. 9. Doth not God then do injustice to man, by requiring from him in His law that which he cannot perform?

A. Not at all; for God made man capable of performing it; but man, by the instigation of the devil, and his own wilful disobedience, deprived himself and all his posterity of those divine gifts.

It is not the purpose of this article to demonstrate that the divine gifts to which the *Heidelberg Catechism* refers include the image of God spoken of in Q. & A. 6 or that those in the Reformed tradition who have spoken of man retaining certain remnants of God's image after the Fall are mistaken. For now, let us consider the principle that, though man was deprived of the gifts which he was given in his original creation, his responsibility has not been diminished. This anticipates the objection to the doctrine that fallen man no longer bears the image of God, that he, therefore, no longer has the attached responsibilities. But, in fact, as our *Catechism* explains, man's wilful disobedience in depriving himself of the capability to perform the required obedience does not remove his responsibility.

The reason that the epistles to the Ephesians and Colossians mention the image of God or *imago dei* in connection with these responsibilities is not, therefore, that fallen man does not also have the responsibility not to lie, etc., but that the Christian has this capability restored to him (along with the actual doing of these works, although not yet perfectly). Having this real capability gives us encouragement to perform our duties (Eph. 2:10; Phil. 2:13). We also have even greater responsibility than man in his original creation, since we have also been re-created by receiving this gracious wonder of regeneration. Our higher responsibility, however, does not remove fallen man's responsibility also to bear God's image.

There are many sins mentioned in contrast to the image of God in these verses but perhaps most emphasized are those sins related to the abuse of the tongue. Bearing God's image requires putting away these sins of the tongue: filthy or corrupt communication, lying and blasphemy. Instead of these, edifying words should proceed from our mouths: we must speak the truth, and we must give thanks and praise to God, teaching and admonishing one another with the Psalms of the Spirit (Eph. 5:19-20).

Ephesians 5:1 summarizes this: "Be ye therefore followers of God, as dear children." We must speak the truth because "He is the Rock, his work is perfect: for all his ways are judgment: a God of truth and without iniquity, just and right is he" (Deut. 32:4). As God cannot lie (Titus 1:2), so His children, who bear His image, must not lie. Likewise, as God glorifies His holy name (John 12:28), so those who bear His image must sanctify and praise His name. Since God's words are pure (Ps. 12:6), our communication must also be pure.

So far, we have looked at our responsibility from the viewpoint of how we ought to bear God's image according to our original creation and our regeneration, but that others are also in God's image also has implications for our responsibility. Regarding the use of the tongue, and specifically this sin of blaspheming mentioned above, James 3:9 is very closely related. Blasphemy is especially to curse or speak evil of God Himself (Lev. 24:11-16). James 3:9-10 highlights an absurdity of some who are careful not to blaspheme: "Therewith bless we God, even the Father; and therewith curse we men, which are made after the similitude of God. Out of the same mouth proceedeth blessing and cursing. My brethren, these things ought not so to be."

We, James observes, do not blaspheme God with our tongues, we bless Him, even praising Him with Psalms (James 5:13). Yet how do we speak of others who bear His image? With the same tongue, we speak evil of them and curse them. This verse has commonly been understood as implying that all men are in God's image, even unregenerate men after the Fall. But, simply from the grammar, this is not necessarily the case. The clause "which are made after the similitude of God" can either identify particular men to which James is referring or else it merely describes all men.

Besides the many arguments that could be brought to argue that the unregenerate are not in God's image, there is one compelling reason which proves that this cannot refer to all men: there are many examples in Scripture of righteous men of God rightly pronouncing curses upon God's enemies. For example, recall those who stood upon mount Ebal to curse according to God's instruction, to which cursing all the people answered "Amen" (Deut. 27:13-26; Josh. 8:33-34). Or consider the inspired song of Deborah and Barak, in which the angel of the Lord calls the people to curse those who did not come to help (Judg. 5:23). Noah also prophesied by cursing Canaan (Gen. 9:25). In case any with Marcionist tendencies think that God's moral law has changed in the light of the New Testament, Paul pronounces *anathema* (i.e., calls down a curse) upon those who love not the Lord (I Cor. 16:22) or who preach any other gospel (Gal. 1:8-9). James is not condemning these curses but the curses against those who are in God's image. They cannot be, and may not be, cursed.

Balak and Balaam discovered this when they attempted to curse God's people (Num. 24:10). Again, because we bear God's image, we ought not

curse those whom God has blessed. But now we see from this verse that God's image in others (the regenerate) also has implications for our responsibility. We may not curse, for example, our Christian brethren who disagree with us on important doctrines, since they are nevertheless in God's image. Even if their teachings or practices might grievously offend or scandalize us or might compromise other more fundamental doctrines (if carried to their logical implications or held more consistently), if correction or doctrinal polemics is necessary, this does not provide any excuse for cursing our believing (though erring) brothers and sisters in Christ who bear God's image with us (Rom. 14:4, 10; Gal. 2:11-14). The warning for us is that cursing will come to those who take pleasure in cursing (Ps. 109:17). Erring brethren are not what Paul calls "enemies of the cross of Christ" or what John calls "antichrists" (Phil. 3:18; I John 2:18, 22). Other passages also deal directly with our responsibility in relation to God's image. It is commonly supposed that Genesis 9:6 is one of these passages, so we will now consider how God's image relates to our responsibility not to murder.

Hating and Murdering

Before we examine Genesis 9:6, we should first consider the passage in the New Testament which discusses murder in the most detail: I John 3:1-19. John identifies hatred as the essence and source of murder, such that the one who hates his brother is actually a murderer (v. 15). In this, John is simply following the explanation given by Christ with regard to the sixth commandment (Matt. 5:21-22). John draws our attention in particular to the example of Cain and Abel. As evidence that Cain was "of that wicked one," he "slew his brother" (I John 3:12). This hatred in contrast to love is ultimately, says John, how the difference between the children of the devil and the children of God is manifest (v. 10). This love is so fundamental to being a child of God, that John presents it to us as a comforting proof that we are no longer dead in sin but alive to God (v. 14). By this love, we ought to know and even assure ourselves that we are "of the truth" (vv. 18-19).

This entire passage is intimately connected to the image or likeness of God. Cain was "of that wicked one" and "not of God" (vv. 10, 12), because he was like the devil and did the works of the devil (cf. John 8:44). The whole idea

of the children of God versus the children of the devil is predicated upon the similarity or likeness of the children to their father. The child bears the image of the father (Gen. 5:3; John 8:39-47). Bearing the image of God, therefore, in the context of I John 3, is especially to be like God by a self-sacrificial love for the brethren (v. 16)—the very opposite of Cain’s murderous hatred. In this context, the love of God dwelling in us is our bearing the image of God (v. 17). Conversely, how is the image of God in those in whom the love of God does not dwell?

Murder, in this passage, is such a monstrous and devilish evil because it is hatred, which is exactly contrary to, and incompatible with, love. Cain, as a descendent of Adam who was originally created in God’s image, had this responsibility to love his brother and thereby show himself to be “of God,” but instead he demonstrated that he was a murderous child of the devil. He behaved contrary to God’s purpose with the creation of man, showing that the love of God did not dwell in him and that he bore Satan’s image rather than God’s.

Cain also hated his brother because Abel’s works were righteous (v. 12). In other words, Cain hated the image of God in Abel, whose righteous works showed that he was like the righteous God for he was born of God (v. 7). John’s application to us is that the world will hate all of us, the sons of God who bear His image, just as Cain hated Abel (vv. 12-13). Notice that it is not particularly Abel’s innocence which makes the crime so wicked (after all, Abel was not sinlessly perfect either)—but chiefly Cain’s hatred.

This lengthy passage may be rightly considered as an apostolic interpretation of the rather brief and less clear treatment of murder in Genesis 9:6. This verse has often been used to attempt to prove that even unregenerate man is still in God’s image. This is done by making two assumptions. First, that the clause “for in the image of God made he man” chiefly refers to the victim of the crime and, second, that the clause actually means that all men are *still* in the image of God. The second point merely begs the question. Grammatically, the verse only says, *in the past tense*, that man was made in God’s image. But we will focus on the first often unspoken assumption.

We have already seen that man’s responsibility with regard to the image of God can relate to the responsibility to bear that image on account of God’s

purpose in man's original creation or to walk according to that image on account of our regeneration or even to consider that image of God in others. There are logically three parties, then, to which the final clause in this verse could refer: the murderer, the victim or the executioner (leaving aside for the moment the questionable interpretation of some that this is not a command but merely a statement of God's intent to use a human instrument to bring judgment on the murderer). Clearly, we know from other passages in Scripture and a general understanding of the image of God that it could reasonably refer to all three in different senses but, rather than assume, we would like to consider which of these may be intended *primarily*.

First, the executioner has a responsibility to bear God's image in justly executing justice by punishing the murderer with death. In this too, man must bear God's image, for man was given dominion over the creation (Gen. 1:26-27) and must execute his office justly as God is just. As a judge and as "children of the most High," man must be like God in righteous judgment (Ps. 82). Neglect of this duty is especially grievous in those who are office-bearers in the church. However, all other crimes besides murder also require proper justice to be executed. This would then only be a more general exhortation to judges rather than a particular reason for murderers to be executed, which does not really fit the context which is emphasizing the crime of murder.

Second, if the victim is in God's image, this crime is especially wicked. To attack and kill God's children is to touch the apple of His eye (Ps. 105:15; Zech. 2:8). To hate one who is in God's image is an expression of hatred against God. We saw that Cain hated his brother because Abel's works were righteous. Undoubtedly, this makes the crime more detestable in God's sight, as a murderous hatred against His own image and His children whom He loves. Nevertheless, if the intention is to establish the need to punish murder, it cannot be with a reason that depends on the victim.

Murder is a very serious crime, worthy of execution, irrespective of how vile or innocent the victim is. Killing a helpless baby in the womb is certainly more despicable than the murder of an adult mass-murderer or a paedophile. Yet all murder must be condemned. If this verse is meant to establish that all murderers must be executed, it makes no sense to relate this to the quality of the victim. Even those who claim that fallen man still retains some remnants

of God's image would have to admit that the Christian, according to their view, bears God's image to a greater extent. This verse cannot be speaking primarily about the victim, therefore.

Third, as we have considered from I John 3, murder is a crime that is especially contrary to God's image. It is a manifestation of hatred towards a brother according to the flesh, since we are all of one blood (Acts 17:26), whereas God is love (I John 4:7-8). As a violation of God's image and as the work of the devil, it is to be punished by execution. The first and greatest commandment is that we should love God and the second is that we should love our neighbour. Such a gross violation of this commandment and such a defiling of the image of God which man was created to bear, is to be punished with death at the hand of a human executioner. There are other considerations as to why murderers must be executed but the emphasis of this text is based upon the murderer's responsibility to bear God's image.

In the context, it is one thing for a beast to kill a man, considering that man was originally created in the image of God in the beginning. In this case, the beast must be put to death (Gen. 9:5). But then the awful crime is intensified when considering the case of a man wilfully murdering another man—a notoriously common crime prior to the Flood, for which men were previously banished rather than executed and as a result of which the earth became full of violence (Gen. 4:8-15, 23-24; 6:11-13). As part of God's covenant promise not to send another such flood, He gives provision for preventing the earth becoming filled with violence again in a way that would require such a flood (Gen. 9:9-15). If the life of a mere beast must be required for such an atrocity, how much more a rational, wilful man, who unlike the ignorant beast ought to display the image of God in holiness, righteousness and knowledge of God? Finally, in the extreme case, a man murders his own brother. In response to this, the seriousness of the command reaches its pinnacle and is repeated in the form of poetic justice and firmly established with reference to man's responsibility to bear God's image.

Various Implications

Once we begin to recognize that the image of God is implied by language such as “of God” or “after God” or “like God” or “as God” or “children of

God,” we can begin to see very many places in Scripture which speak of our responsibility in those terms. Many examples could be given. “But as he which hath called you is holy, so be ye holy in all manner of conversation; Because it is written, Be ye holy; for I am holy” (I Pet. 1:15-16). Here we are called to be holy because we ought to be like God, bearing His holy image. True peacemakers also bear God’s image because He is “the God of peace” (Phil. 4:9): “Blessed are the peacemakers: for they shall be called the children of God” (Matt. 5:9). The children of God must bear His image by loving and doing good to the unthankful, unjust and evil, since while we were yet sinners, Christ died for us (Rom. 5:6-10):

That ye may be the children of your Father which is in heaven: for he maketh his sun to rise on the evil and on the good, and sendeth rain on the just and on the unjust. For if ye love them which love you, what reward have ye? do not even the publicans the same? And if ye salute your brethren only, what do ye more than others? do not even the publicans so? Be ye therefore perfect, even as your Father which is in heaven is perfect (Matt. 5:45-48).

Because He is “the only wise God” (I Tim. 1:17) understanding His own will (I Cor. 2:9-16), we must bear His image in being wise:

See then that ye walk circumspectly, not as fools, but as wise, Redeeming the time, because the days are evil. Wherefore be ye not unwise, but understanding what the will of the Lord is (Eph. 5:15-17).

The Son of man came eating and drinking, and they say, Behold a man gluttonous, and a winebibber, a friend of publicans and sinners. But wisdom is justified of her children (Matt. 11:19).

To be the children of light, bearing the image of the One who is light and in whom is no darkness at all (I John 1:5), we must believe in the light and walk as children of light:

While ye have light, believe in the light, that ye may be the children of light (John 12:36).

For ye were sometimes darkness, but now are ye light in the Lord: walk as children of light (Eph. 5:8).

Ye are all the children of light, and the children of the day: we are not of the night, nor of darkness (I Thess. 5:5).

Examples could be multiplied and far more could be written on this subject. Indeed, all our responsibilities according to God's law could be related to our responsibility to bear God's image according to His purpose with our creation.

Finally, after saying this much about man and his creation, let us consider how the rest of creation relates to man as he is called to bear God's image:

For the earnest expectation of the creature waiteth for the manifestation of the sons of God. For the creature was made subject to vanity, not willingly, but by reason of him who hath subjected the same in hope, Because the creature itself also shall be delivered from the bondage of corruption into the glorious liberty of the children of God (Rom. 8:19-21).

All of creation awaits the day when man will once again bear the image of God in perfection, when the children of the devil who bear his image are cast into the lake of fire (Rev. 20:15). All of creation has been groaning for the children of God to be revealed bearing His glorious image ever since that image was lost at the Fall.

The loss of that image is the source of the creation's pain and frustration, because all creation was placed under the dominion of man. It was good for the creation when man bore the divine image but the creation was subjected to vanity when man cast aside that image for the devil's. This too was God's purpose even in the beginning. Because God made man to bear His image, there was and is nothing that the devil could do to prevent that image being restored to man, through our Lord Jesus Christ who is the image of the invisible God (II Cor. 4:4; Col. 1:15; Heb. 1:3).

